

BRIDAL AIR

Buoyed by skyrocketing land prices, cash-rich rural India swaps the wedding horse for the helicopter



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■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Excitement pulses through the crowd waiting at a makeshift helipad in Sihani, a village in Faridabad, Haryana, as the white Bell Jet Ranger clatters into view. This is no politician arriving to address a rally, but the bridegroom Vinay Tyagi's ride into his bride's village in Kumheda, 25 km away. A modern twist to an age-old practice. The thrill is palpable as the brown prop wash kicked up by the rotors envelopes the marriage party and the chopper fades from view. Mangat Tyagi, an 80-year-old farmer, another one of rural India's sons-of-the-soil grins in satisfaction. He has just spent a whopping Rs 4 lakh on a four-hour ride and lent a new meaning to the term conspicuous consumption. "We wanted to do some-

thing different for our brother's wedding," says property dealer Bir Singh Tyagi.

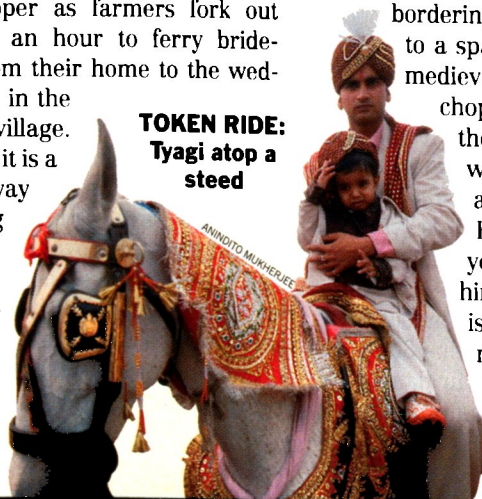
Tyagi senior, who reportedly pocketed Rs 80 crore in selling half of his 100-bigha ancestral holding to builders, is not alone. These days the white charger is being swapped for a sleek chopper as farmers fork out Rs 55,000 an hour to ferry bridegrooms from their home to the wedding venue in the bride's village. Like Tyagi, it is a sure-fire way of ensuring permanence for an ostentatious but fleeting social

FLYING HIGH: Bridegroom Vinay Tyagi (second from left) with his family

event and of assuring their children have, well, marriages made in heaven.

In a country where less than 3 per cent of Indians get to see the insides of a commercial aircraft, a helicopter landing in a village, even one bordering a city, is equivalent to a spacecraft landing in a medieval village. Hiring a chopper is the cherry on the cake, a booming wedding industry with a turnover of roughly Rs 40,000 crore per year. "The concept of hiring a helicopter itself is so heavy that the marriage parties forget to ask us to festoon it with the

TOKEN RIDE: Tyagi atop a steed



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